UN-REFEREED ARTIST TALKS

Abstracts

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ABSTRACT

This presentation explores 'Macau Days', a collaboration between John Young (Artist), Brian Castro (Poet) and Luke Harrald (Composer / Sound Artist). An interdisciplinary gallery installation and tri-lingual book, the work incorporates a range of cross-sensory materials that respond to the rich and eclectic history of Macau; its mythical figures, culture, music, literature and cuisine.

The sound installation for the work draws on Harrald's previous body of work that aims to shape our perception of place, and sense of Dasein - or "being there" - through offering an audience experience that blends real and composed sonic environments, and constantly shifts the listener's sense of perspective within the diegesis of the work. The boundaries of diegesis in electro-acoustic music are often more difficult to define than in traditional western music due to the relationship the recorded materials have with everyday sounds. In sound installation works, this ambiguity is advantageous as it draws the listener in to relating the sound materials presented within the space with their own previous experiences.

Macau Days takes a particularly innovative approach to audio spatialisation, incorporating a quadraphonic surround system and three Holosonic panels mounted above the audience. The Holosonic panels create three columns of sound within the overarching surround mix. As the work is based on six poems by Castro, that are published in three languages, this approach allows for the simultaneous presentation of the poems in English, Portuguese and Mandarin.

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ABSTRACT

The materialisation of sound as audio recording opens the potential for operations to be carried out on sounds: editing, montage, signal processing, mixing, sequencing, etc. Pierre Schaeffer practised an empirical method of composition, composed listening or composing by ear. This marks it as related to oral traditions rather than the literate. Friedrich Kittler notes that the typewriter objectified the word onto the page as a fixed medium. With the word processor that medium became virtual and flexible, allowing for the playing with montage techniques first developed for cinema. Using the metaphor of writing with sound, one can draw an analogy between empirical composition with sound objects and literary text production in the age of the DAW.

Literary text production theory offers a number of concepts useful for empirical composition: dialogism; heterophony; intertextuality included; and offers ways of understanding how sounds are rendered semantically meaningful. Glenn Gould (montage music); Mauricio Kagel (musicalization of speech); and Stockhausen (music approaches speech: speech approaches music) explored these dramaturgical relations in their speech-based composition and sound studio production.